Skills assignment 4: Qualitative instrument

Due Thursday, October 8, 2026

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Task 0: Context

We are diagnosing why some students in group-work-intensive, project-based classrooms report low belonging despite strong academic and creative engagement. Our starting point is Eagle Chan's Grade 7 Design course. Students work in small groups on a year-long pop-up storybook project, and their groups often change.

Strategy question: What conditions in group work contribute to students' sense of belonging, and which could we change?

This instrument explores one Five Whys hypothesis: **short, timed group tasks may leave too little room for some students to contribute, which may affect belonging.** The hypothesis is about activity design, not a claim that students' language skills are deficient. We will also listen for other explanations, including how often groups change.

Task 1: Choose a data collection method

We will use individual in-depth interviews. The J-PAL reading says to weigh the depth of information needed, topic sensitivity, interviewer skill, and available time (David & Paul, n.d.). We need each student's account of specific group-work moments, and feeling left out is hard to discuss in front of classmates. A focus group could discourage honest disagreement. Observation would show who speaks, not what it meant to the student. Because Eagle teaches all six sections, students may hold back with him, so Frederick will interview if the school approves. Interviewer skill is our main constraint. We will practice, pilot the guide, and have the school counselor review it before any interview.

Task 2: Select respondents

We will use maximum-variation purposive sampling. We want to hear different experiences, not estimate how common any one is. Our target is 12 Grade 7 Design students, two per section. We will interview one student per section first, review which perspectives are missing, then invite the second. Twelve is a time limit, not a claim of saturation: at 40 minutes each, it takes eight interview hours, plus piloting and analysis.

Within sections, we will vary time at school, home language, and comfort speaking in groups, using a short voluntary form. Belonging ratings will inform selection only if they exist and the school approves. School staff, not the student panel, will apply the criteria privately. If a section has no willing student, we will report the gap. We will not substitute an easier-to-recruit student. Refusal will not affect grades or groups. Consent, interpreter, and safeguarding arrangements appear under "Before use" in Task 3.

Task 3: Interview instrument

Before use (required; not counted in the prose limit)

The team must confirm and document each item below before recruiting or interviewing any student.

1. **School approval:** written approval from school leaders for the study and the interview plan.
2. **Permission:** family permission and student agreement (assent) procedures, following school policy.
3. **Safeguarding:** the name of the counselor or contact who receives any safety concern, and the school's reporting steps.
4. **Interviewer:** confirmation that Frederick has no say over students' grades or groups. If he does, the school names another interviewer.

5. **Language support:** a confidential, trained interpreter or bilingual interviewer. Peers and relatives never interpret. If none exists, we offer English interviews only and report that limit.
6. **Data:** a private room, secure storage, and a list of the people who may see identifiable notes. Eagle receives only combined, de-identified findings.

Setting

Private school-approved space. Up to 40 minutes, including the opening and closing. Follow the student's account, and treat probes as options, not a checklist. Skip any probe the student has already answered. Offer a break at any time and after Stem 5. Accept speaking, writing, or drawing. Ask students to explain their own writing or drawing, and do not interpret it for them.

Opening script (draft; the school must approve the final wording before use)

"Thank you for meeting with me. I want to understand what group work in Design is like for students. There are no right or wrong answers. Taking part is your choice. It will not affect your grades or your groups. You can skip any question, take a break, or stop at any time. I will not share your answers with your classmates or with Mr. Chan. When we report what we learn, we will remove names and combine answers, but we cannot promise that no one could ever guess who said something. One exception: if I hear that someone may be unsafe or being hurt, I need to tell the school counselor so they can help. Do you have any questions? Do you still want to take part?"

If a student becomes upset or mentions possible harm: pause, offer a break, and follow the confirmed school reporting steps. Do not ask extra questions to investigate. Every student leaves knowing how to reach the counselor.

Stems and probes

Stem 1 (warm-up): Tell me about a recent Design lesson.

- **Probe 1a:** What were you working on? *(Establish the activity.)*

- **Probe 1b:** What part do you remember most? *(Learn what the student notices without suggesting a problem.)*
- **Goal:** Build comfort and set a concrete lesson context before we discuss group work.

Stem 2 (working with peers): Tell me about a group you have worked with in Design.

- **Probe 2a:** How did that group get together? *(Learn how grouping worked in this case.)*
- **Probe 2b:** What was it like to work with them? *(Invite the student's own account.)*
- **Probe 2c:** What made this group stand out for you? *(Identify what the student considers important. Do not mention group changes unless the student does.)*
- **Goal:** Understand the lived experience of grouping, including supports or difficulties we did not predict.

Stem 3 (time and contribution): Tell me about a group task in Design when there was not much time.

- **Probe 3a:** What happened as your group worked? *(Establish the sequence of events.)*
- **Probe 3b:** How were ideas shared? *(See how contributions happened without assuming everyone spoke.)*
- **Probe 3c:** How, if at all, did that experience affect how you felt about working with the group? *(Explore the possible link between time pressure and belonging, and allow "no effect.")*
- **Conditional probe:** You mentioned [the student's own words about speed, language, or another factor]. Tell me more about that. *(Follow the student's explanation and do not introduce ours.)*
- **If no timed task comes to mind:** "Tell me about another group task you remember." Do not press for an example.
- **Goal:** Test the proposed path from task conditions to contribution to belonging, while leaving room for the path to be absent.

Stem 4 (feeling part of a group): Tell me what working in a group is usually like for you in Design.

- **Probe 4a:** Tell me about a time when you felt part of your group. *(Ground belonging in a real moment. If nothing comes to mind, skip it and do not press.)*
- **Probe 4b:** What did someone do or say that mattered to you? *(Identify specific actions, if any.)*
- **Probe 4c:** What does "feeling part of the group" mean to you? *(Check whether the student's meaning matches our one-item rating.)*
- **Goal:** Capture the student's everyday experience first, and ground "belonging" in their definition, not ours.

Stem 5 (optional; the student may skip): Think of another time you worked in a Design group. What was that like for you?

- **Probe 5a:** How was it different from the group you just described? *(Invite comparison without assuming it was worse.)*
- **Probe 5b (only if the student describes difficulty):** What, if anything, would have helped? *(Let the student name changes.)*
- **Asked once:** "Have there been times you felt less part of a group? You do not have to give an example." *(Make room for an experience the open stem may not bring out, without pressing for details.)*
- **Goal:** Learn about variation, including possible exclusion, without presenting exclusion as the expected answer. Accept a short answer or refusal and move on.

Stem 6 (wind-down): What else should someone trying to understand group work in Design know?

- **Probe 6a:** What would you keep the same? *(Identify practices students value.)*
- **Probe 6b:** What have I not asked that matters to you? *(Surface issues our guide missed.)*

- **Goal:** Give the student the last word and end away from the sensitive topic.

Closing

Thank the student and remind them how to reach the counselor. After analysis, send all Design students the same short written summary of combined themes, with no section labels and no distinctive quotations. Include an anonymous comment box so any student can correct or add to our interpretation without revealing who took part.

Task 4: Reflect on the instrument

Twelve interviews cannot show how common low belonging is. Belonging ratings could show its spread, and observation could show how students share work, including behavior they do not recall. Neither replaces students' own accounts of what those moments meant. Adult authority and small numbers per section may still limit what students say and what we can safely report. Our hypothesis about timed tasks could lead us to over-read quiet moments as exclusion or to ask too much about language. We will start with concrete, open accounts, follow the student's own words, and record cases where timed work had no effect. We will pilot the guide with two students outside the sample and revise unclear wording. In analysis, we will code what students describe, including surprises and contradictions, before comparing themes with our hypothesis. We will report only combined themes, with no section labels or distinctive quotations.

References

David, T., & Paul, E. (n.d.). *Implementing qualitative methods in the field*. J-PAL.

AI-use documentation

During the preparation of this work, we used ChatGPT to improve readability and language, check grammar and clarity. After using this tool, we reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content.